computers. Just as it is often best to set a thief to catch a thief, so we can use one algorithm to vet another.

This raises the question of how we can be sure that the vetting algorithm itself is reliable. Ultimately, there is no purely technological solution to this recursive problem. No matter which technology we develop, we will have to maintain bureaucratic institutions that will audit algorithms and give or refuse them the seal of approval. Such institutions will combine the powers of humans and computers to make sure that new algorithmic systems are safe and fair. Without such institutions, even if we pass laws that provide humans with a right to an explanation, and even if we enact regulations against computer biases, who could enforce these laws and regulations?

NOSEDIVE

To vet algorithms, regulatory institutions will need not only to analyse them but also to translate their discoveries into stories that humans can understand. Otherwise, we will never trust the regulatory institutions and might instead put our faith in conspiracy theories and charismatic leaders. As noted in chapter 3, it has always been difficult for humans to understand bureaucracy, because bureaucracies have deviated from the script of the biological dramas, and most artists have lacked the will or the ability to depict bureaucratic dramas. For example, novels, movies and TV series about twenty-first-century politics tend to focus on the feuds and love affairs of a few powerful families, as if present-day states were governed in the same way as ancient tribes and kingdoms. This artistic fixation with the biological dramas of dynasties obscures the very real changes that have taken place over the centuries in the dynamics of power.

Because computers will increasingly replace human bureaucrats and human myth-makers, this will again change the deep structure of power. To survive, democracies require not just dedicated bureaucratic institutions that can scrutinise these new structures but also artists who can explain the new structures in accessible and entertaining ways. For example, this has successfully been done by the episode ‘Nosedive’ in the sci-fi series *Black Mirror*.

Produced in 2016, at a time when few had heard about social credit systems, ‘Nosedive’ brilliantly explained how such systems work and what